

Melania Trump denied ties to Jeffrey Epstein. The question remains: Why now?

BY [THE ASSOCIATED PRESS](#)

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WASHINGTON (AP) — First lady Melania Trump's seemingly out-of-the-blue [statement](#) Thursday denying affiliation with disgraced sex trafficker [Jeffrey Epstein](#) left people still wondering Friday what prompted the public declaration at a time when the case had receded from the spotlight.

Reading prepared remarks at the White House on Thursday, Melania Trump said she and her attorneys were fighting back against “unfounded and baseless lies” in regards to her connections to the late financier, a convicted sex offender who leveraged connections to the rich, powerful and famous to recruit his victims and cover up his crimes.

“The lies linking me with the disgraceful Jeffrey Epstein need to end today,” she said. “The individuals lying

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reject their mean-spirited attempts to defame my reputation.

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The first lady didn't take questions from the press after her statement, leaving many with questions:



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AP AUDIO: What to know about Melania Trump's statement denying knowledge of Jeffrey Epstein's crimes



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It's unclear.

The message came as her husband, President [Donald Trump](#), and his administration had finally seemed to move past more than a year of controversy surrounding Epstein, especially as the Iran war had become all-consuming in Washington.

The first lady's comments almost assuredly will serve to push the story back into the political spotlight even as the president urged the public and media to move on from the case.

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Who was Melania Trump responding to?

Melania Trump seemingly referenced a brief email from 2002 with the sender and recipient blacked out. It begins, "Dear G!" and ends "Love, Melania," and compliments the recipient on a magazine article about "JE."

"I know you are very busy flying all over the world," it says. "How was Palm Beach? I cannot wait to go down. Give me a call when you are back in NY."

That email was sent the same month that a New York Magazine article was published about Epstein in which Trump called him a "terrific guy."

Melania Trump said Thursday that she was not friends with Epstein or his confidant and onetime girlfriend [Ghislaine Maxwell](#), but was in overlapping social circles in New York and Florida. She described an email reply she sent to Maxwell as "casual correspondence" without elaborating.

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